

Limitations of Grad Cafe Data

The Grad Cafe data is a plethora of information about the application process of the current grad school climate alongside the different requirements that go into acceptances and rejections. Anyone can submit anonymously, so the results in my database reflect people who cared enough to report, and often had a result they wanted to share or talk about. Hence, there are no official checks on the full validity of the information. Applicants who never heard of the site, or who just don't post, are missing, and the data probably leans toward people who are active online, applying to competitive programs, and applying in the most recent cycle: 83% of my entries are Fall 2026 and about 69% are PhD applicants. That means the statistical nature of my data represents only a sample of posters and applicants in general. My average GRE Quantitative of 165.68 is a good example. If the broader average is around 157, like the example in the assignment, it does not mean that applicants really average 165. Only 1,176 of my 40,007 entries (2.9%) include a usable GRE Quantitative score, people with strong scores are probably more willing to post them, and the site may attract a lot of applicants to competitive programs. So the average is a fact about the entries that included the score, and it can't tell me what the real applicant population looks like.

Even for the people who are represented in the data, the information is self-reported and messy. Nobody verifies a GPA or a decision, so people can round up, make typos, or use different scales. When I first calculated averages, Grad Cafe stored blank scores as 0, which dragged my average GRE Quantitative down to about 21. I also found GPAs out of 10 and GRE scores from the old 200 to 800 scale. I treated those as missing, but I can't be sure I caught every bad value that still looks normal. The missing values are not random either: 59.6% of entries have a GPA but only 2.9% have a GRE Quantitative, and 66.3% of accepted entries include a GPA compared with 57.6% of rejected ones, so what gets reported depends on the outcome. People with good news, or with a very unusual result, may also be more likely to post. This could be why the average GPA of rejected Fall 2026 applicants (3.78) came out slightly higher than accepted ones (3.76), which is not a believable real effect and may just reflect who reports and how. In conclusion, the database mathematically contains the averages and percentages I calculated, but it does not provide well enough information to conclude how admissions really work or how likely a certain applicant is to get in. At most it lets me describe what people chose to report.